

Japanese capture of Pusan
The main Japanese landing was at Pusan at the southern tip of the Korean peninsula. The invaders were able to repel all attempts to retake the port, but convoys to and from Pusan were always vulnerable.

JAPANESE INVASION OF KOREA

CHILCHONRYANG



Date July 16, 1597
Forces Koreans: 166 ships; Japanese: c.500 ships
Losses Koreans: 153 ships; Japanese: unknown

Location Chilchonryang, off southern Korea

In 1597, command of the Korean navy was entrusted to Won Kyun, promoted in place of the disgraced Yi Sunshin. Urged by the royal court to take an aggressive stance, Won Kyun led the entire Korean fleet to attack the Japanese at Pusan.

The Japanese appeared in overwhelming strength and brought the Koreans to battle on their own terms. As the Korean fleet was ill-coordinated, the Japanese were able to impose a close-quarters mêlée in which the Koreans could not use their cannon, while the Japanese were able to grapple and board the ships of their enemies. Korean ships that attempted to flee were pursued and captured. Those who sought to escape to shore on nearby Kojedo Island, including Won Kyun, were massacred by the island's Japanese garrison. Only 13 Korean warships, which had prudently fled before the fighting began, survived the debacle.

JAPANESE INVASION OF KOREA

MYONGYANG



Date September 16, 597
Forces Koreans: 13 ships; Japanese: 133 ships
Losses Koreans: none; Japanese: 31 ships

Location Myongyang Strait, southwest Korea

Encouraged by their overwhelming victory at Chilchonryang, the Japanese sought to destroy the remnants of the Korean navy and to take control of the Yellow Sea, opening up a maritime supply line along the west coast of Korea to their armies, which were advancing to the north. There was no time to rebuild the Korean navy, but on the advice of his counselors the king belatedly reinstated Yi Sunshin to the command of what was left of it. On his way to resume his duties as admiral, Yi wrote to the Korean royal court: "As I am alive, the enemies will never gain the Western Seas."



Korean quiver
Archers played a major role in Korea's naval victories over Japan, making extensive use of fire arrows to attack the flimsy Japanese ships.

Admiral Yi had only 13 serviceable *panokseons* with which to confront the Japanese, but he took advantage of his knowledge of local conditions to even the odds. After fighting a holding action at Oranpo he withdrew to the Myongyang Strait, which separates Jindo Island from the mainland. The strait has strong currents that change direction every three hours. Yi Sunshin correctly anticipated that the Japanese fleet would enter the strait when the current was favorable to carry them toward the Yellow Sea.

MIRACULOUS VICTORY

Yi placed his ships across the western end of the strait so that the Japanese were borne toward his cannon on the current. A well-coordinated barrage of shot, abetted by fire arrows, threw the Japanese van into confusion. The admiral in command of the van, Kurushima Michifusa, was blown overboard and his body drifted to the Korean line. Yi had the admiral's head cut off and stuck on a masthead. When the current changed the Korean ships were carried down at speed upon the demoralized and disorganized Japanese, who left 31 blazing or sinking vessels behind them as they fled in disorder. The battle is known to Koreans as the "miracle of Myongyang" because of the unlikely balance of forces between the victors and the defeated.

JAPANESE INVASION OF KOREA

NORYANG



Date November 19, 1598
Forces Koreans and Chinese: 150 ships; Japanese: c.500 ships
Losses Koreans and Chinese: 1 ship lost; Japanese: c.200 ships sunk, 100 captured

Location Noryang Strait, southern Korea

In the autumn of 1598, with their leader Toyotomi Hideyoshi dead and with the Chinese having now entered the war in support of Korea, the Japanese were hastening to extricate themselves from their ill-judged Korean adventure.

On November 18 some 200,000 Japanese troops had embarked on a large fleet of transport ships, their aim to join up with other Japanese forces and return to Japan. A combined fleet of Korean and Chinese warships was blockading the Japanese-held fortresses along the southern coast of Korea. Chen Lin, commanding the Chinese squadron of 65 warships, favored making a deal to let the Japanese go. But Yi Sunshin, with 85 Korean *panokseons* and turtle ships, was not prepared to allow the enemy to escape unmolested, and his view prevailed. The combined fleet waited at the entrance to the narrow Noryang Strait.

Commanded by Shimazu Yoshihiro, the vast Japanese convoy approached the strait at night and blundered into the Korean and Chinese ships in the early hours of the morning. With large numbers of ships clashing in darkness in confined waters, the conflict was inevitably confused. The Japanese fought desperately to open a passage through the strait; the Koreans and Chinese struggled to stop them. The mêlée favored the Japanese, who could bring their arquebus fire to bear at close quarters. One Chinese ship was taken by the Japanese and all on board slaughtered. Chen Lin's flagship was boarded and only narrowly saved from capture. Yet dawn revealed that the allied fleet had triumphed, with hundreds of Japanese transports captured or sunk.

Yi led the pursuit of the Japanese ships that had broken through and were heading for Pusan, but in the course of the action, he was shot dead. This fact was concealed until the combat was over. One week after the battle, the Japanese army sailed from Pusan back to Japan, and the war came to an end.



Death of Yi Sunshin
Like Nelson, Yi was killed in his hour of triumph, struck by a stray shot fired by an enemy arquebusier. The captain on his flagship had been lucky to escape with his life when an arquebus ball hit his helmet.